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Presenting the augmented self: extending sender effects of the hyperpersonal model in artificial intelligence-mediated communication

Rui (Cara) Zhu[1,*], David M. Markowitz[1], Brandon Van Der Heide[1]

[1]Department of Communication, Michigan State University, East Lansing, MI, United States
*Corresponding author: Department of Communication, Michigan State University, 404 Wilson Road, East Lansing, MI 48824, United States. Email: zhurui1@msu.edu.

Abstract

Artificial intelligence (AI) has been increasingly used to facilitate interpersonal communication. To provide a theoretical account of how the use of AI may affect interpersonal communication, we extend the hyperpersonal model by conceptualizing AI-mediated communication (AIMC) as computer-mediated communication (CMC) with an AI layer that participates in message production. Focusing on the sender side of the hyperpersonal model, namely selective self-presentation, we propose 2 AIMC affordances (i.e., co-creation and adaptability) and argue that these 2 affordances systematically reshape selective self-presentation by changing the production of both content (i.e., what to say) and language style (i.e., how to say it) of self-presentation. Using traditional CMC as the benchmark, we derive propositions specifying how self-presentation in AIMC differs from CMC, how these differences translate into impression and relational outcomes, and how they affect senders' psychology. This article results in a theoretical framework called the Computational-Assisted Relational Exchange model, which advances a research program that investigates the changes introduced by AIMC relative to CMC and shows how classical CMC theories can be revisited, reexamined, and extended to account for the mechanisms involved.

Keywords hyperpersonal model, artificial intelligence-mediated communication, selective self-presentation, affordances, computer-mediated communication

People are often concerned about how they are perceived by others and seek to manage those impressions in social interactions (Goffman, 1959). As social interactions increasingly take place online, everyday impression management also unfolds in online settings. In an online environment, individuals adapt to the online communication environment to present themselves in desirable ways (Walther, 1992b). In computer-mediated communication (CMC), as proposed by the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996), the asynchronicity, editability, and reduced-cue affordances of CMC channels give individuals control over their images and allow them to strategically select which cues they present and how they present them. A developing trend is artificial intelligence-mediated communication (AIMC), in which artificial intelligence (AI) facilitates human–human interaction (Hancock et al., 2020). In this form of mediated communication, AI assists in message production and has the potential to transform selective self-presentation, both in its processes and its consequences.

Having AI as an assistant in crafting one's online persona is no longer rare (Cunningham, 2025; Field, 2024; Mok, 2023). Consider the everyday self-presentation scenarios: creating a dating-app profile after moving to a new country. The newcomer wants to show attractiveness to local potential dates while staying true to themselves. Lacking a firm sense of local norms, for instance, how much to disclose, which humor reads well, what counts as polite, the newcomer must decide what to include and how to phrase it. It may take considerable time to decide on content and to weigh word choice and tone. Today, AI tools are increasingly being used to assist with these tasks. Today's AI tools specialize across the writing workflow, from micro-level aids (e.g., text suggestions, auto-correct, auto-completions) to full content generation from prompts. AI tools like ChatGPT, as well as specialized apps such as RIZZ, now help users draft profiles, generate opening messages, and even compose break-up texts (Wicklund, 2024). Surveys highlight the growing relevance of this trend. For instance, a 2025 study of U.S. singles found that nearly half of Gen Z reported using AI in their dating experiences, ranging from profile creation to conversational assistance (Match, 2025).

The growing trend of using AI to facilitate interpersonal communication raises important theoretical questions that previous CMC theories have not addressed. Whereas previous CMC theories and frameworks, such as the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996), treated communication channels as mere conduits for message delivery, in AIMC, AI participates in the message production process (Hancock et al., 2020). As AI systems become

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capable of generating human-like language cues once exclusive to human communicators, it prompts questions about how AIMC reflects or changes interpersonal processes and dynamics, and how such changes translate to impression and relationship development.

This article treats self-presentation as the sender-side dimension of AIMC, asking whether AIMC introduces systematic differences in self-presentation compared with traditional CMC and what relational and psychological consequences follow. Although prior work has begun to map when people use AI in interpersonal settings (Liu et al., 2025), and the effects of AI-assisted self-presentation on language use and topic choice (Fu et al., 2024; Hohenstein et al., 2023), the field still lacks a comprehensive and theoretically integrated account of how AIMC shapes the processes of message encoding and the consequences of using AI for self-presentation. Having a comprehensive and theoretically integrated account of how AIMC shapes message encoding and self-presentation is necessary, as it helps bring together fragmented existing evidence, especially when AI-mediated self-presentation involves a complex interplay of technological affordances, relational dynamics, and individual psychological mechanisms.

Drawing on the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996), we discuss how AIMC may reshape selective self-presentation and what relational and psychological outcomes may follow from its use. Developed in the 1990s as a response to views that CMC is impersonal because of reduced nonverbal cues (e.g., Daft & Lengel, 1984; Kiesler et al., 1984, Short et al., 1976), the hyperpersonal model and social information processing theory (SIP) emphasized users' motivated adaptation to the medium affordances to achieve relational goals (Walther, 1992b, 1996). Following this model, this article aims to offer a theory-driven account of AI-mediated self-presentation. The objective of this article is to use the hyperpersonal model as a theoretical anchor to explore: (a) What are the specific affordances of AIMC that relevant to AI-mediated self-presentation? (b) How does the process of selective self-presentation change when AI is involved as a function of the new affordances? and (c) to propose a theoretical model with propositions that can guide predictions about the affordances and process as well as the outcomes.

Scope conditions

Before proceeding, it is important to clarify the scope conditions of this article to establish the foundation for the discussion. First, we extend the sender effects of the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996), that is, selective self-presentation, to the context of AIMC. The hyperpersonal model proposed four interrelated classes of effects (i.e., sender, receiver, channel, and feedback) that explain how CMC can facilitate more idealized social connections than face-to-face (FtF) communication. In the hyperpersonal model, selective self-presentation by the sender operates at the message-encoding stage, which shapes what receivers decode subsequently and sets the conditions under which self-presentational choices influence back on the sender's psychology. AIMC, by definition, places AI in the encoding process, operating on the sender's behalf in producing messages (Hancock et al., 2020). Following this definition, in AIMC, AI functions primarily as a sender-side tool, which makes sender-focused examinations the logical starting point for theory development and the most direct way to extend CMC to AIMC before layering receiver, channel, and feedback dynamics.

Second, this article is concerned with AIMC, where AI is an added layer to the traditional CMC. In AIMC, AI assists message production in exchanges between two humans, rather than acting as a communication partner. This distinguishes the present inquiry from human–machine communication and human–AI interaction research, as it centers on interpersonal dynamics within AIMC. Hancock et al. (2020) defined AIMC as "interpersonal communication that is not simply transmitted by technology, but modified, augmented, or even generated by a computational agent to achieve communication goals" (p. 90). This definition helpfully captures the breadth of AI use in interpersonal contexts, but its breadth also poses challenges for theoretical specification. The three actions (i.e., augmentation, modification, and generation) bundle together practices that may entail different human–AI control dynamics and psychological processes. This creates challenges for theory building, given that internal consistency is a core criterion of theory construction (Chaffee & Berger, 1987). We, therefore, propose a narrow definition of AI-mediated self-presentation that clearly draws on AIMC research, but is more specific in its components based on the aims of the present work: *AI-mediated self-presentation reflects self-presentation practices in CMC where users strategically employ AI tools to augment or modify their own draft messages, or to generate draft messages under their review and approval, while retaining authorship of intent and content, to shape how others perceive them.* This definition excludes AI uses that are fully automated and unreviewed by the human sender (e.g., Endacott & Leonardi, 2022). Because self-presentation is an intentional process of controlling cues sent to others, excluding fully automatic AI generation keeps the construct aligned with prior theorization of self-presentation grounded in sender intention, editing, and strategic control (Walther, 1996). It is also worth noting that, although this article uses the term AI-*mediated* self-presentation, it does not imply that AI functions as the channel or medium that carries messages between communicators, as CMC treats the computer (Carr, 2020). Rather, in this account, AI is an added layer on the sender side of traditional CMC. The AI layer can reshape the cues that are encoded and then transmitted through the computer (e.g., wording, tone, topic selection), but AI itself does not transmit the cues; the CMC channel still does.

Third, this article focuses on text-related AI use, where both the users' inputs and AI outputs are textual, and text-based self-presentation. Multimodal AI (e.g., images, audio, video) is not considered. A practical rationale for focusing on text is the relatively high prevalence of text-related AI use. In OpenAI's ChatGPT usage report, from May 2024 to June 2025, writing consistently occupied a top share that stayed above 24% of all messages, while multimedia remained below 8% (Chatterji et al., 2025). Theoretically, the hyperpersonal model was originally proposed to explain text-based CMC and then extended to multimodal contexts, making text a logical starting point for extending the hyperpersonal model in AIMC. Moreover, although multimodal tools exist, text remains a major channel for interpersonal communication, meaning-making, and collaboration, and the underlying mechanisms likely differ by modality (Adkins & Brashers, 1995; Clark, 1996; Pennebaker, 2011). Because AIMC

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involves a sender's use of AI, we assume that senders have control over whether and how AI-suggested content is incorporated into the final self-presentational message, they have sufficient AI literacy to use AI for self-presentation purposes, and they can engage with AI output reflectively.

Finally, while the hyperpersonal model was developed to explain relational dynamics in CMC as compared to FtF interaction, the current paper takes traditional CMC without AI augmentation as the baseline but does not suggest comparisons of AIMC with FtF communication. Conceptual definitions of the key concepts in this article are provided in Table 1. One important departure from and extension of the hyperpersonal model in this paper is that the original hyperpersonal model treats the computer primarily as a channel that passively transmits messages between human communicators. AIMC differs in that AI is an added layer to CMC that can contribute to message production, while the sender remains responsible for and the final arbiter of the content. This extension revises the hyperpersonal model's assumption of the sender's solo authorship and fully sender-controlled message production.

We argue that revising this assumption opens new directions for theorizing AIMC, including having human–AI conversational dynamics during composition and systematic tendencies in AI-generated language that may shape senders' verbal behavior as core building blocks for theorization (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026). Also, consistent with the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996), we do not explicitly specify relational context in our theorization. We assume that the processes and effects proposed in this article are generally applicable across different relational contexts, although their strength may vary depending on differences in relational history and expectancy across relationship types.

Before we proceed with our literature review and the explication of our theoretical propositions, we believe it is prudent to reinforce the scope of this article. AIMC is a growing and evolving technological space that facilitates a range of use cases, making self-presentation and sender effects salient in human–human communication. In fact, we anticipate readers of our article will think of different uses of AI in human–human communication and question if our theoretical explication fits their own particular context of interest. The point of our article is larger than a single use case, as our underlying theoretical argument is not specific to a certain AI tool, LLM, or setting of AI use. Instead, the focus of this work concerns human relationships in which communication is mediated through CMC channels that incorporate text-based AI. Our theorization specifically focuses on what humans can do with AI to facilitate interpersonal communication and what AIMC can enable in such relationships (and what AIMC might change about such human–human relationships). Although we acknowledge that the potential for relationships between humans and communication technologies is multifaceted and important (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026), our approach is to explicate a theoretical approach that generalizes across evolving AI systems, across varied human relationships, and to preserve explanatory and predictive power as technologies, models, and platforms change. In our opinion, this is precisely the role and power of theory: to provide "logically coherent and inter-related propositions or conjectures" that offer explanatory mechanisms or that can help to "derive testable and falsifiable predictions" that can apply across settings (Levine & Markowitz, 2024, p. 156). Empirical tests of such predictions will assess the validity of such theoretical contentions. Moreover, we concentrate our theorization on factors most directly related to or derived from the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996). While we recognize and acknowledge that multiple factors may affect components of our positions and predictions discussed here, as a theoretical extension of the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996), this article aims to demonstrate how a classic CMC theory remains useful for explaining and theorizing newly emerging phenomena. Because of our focus, we leave those additional factors to the *Future directions* section in the *Discussion*.

The hyperpersonal model: the history and review

Communication scholars' interest in the effects of computer technologies on human communication dates to the 1970s, with the emergence and proliferation of new communication

Table 1 Definitions of the key concepts.

Concept	Definition
Self-presentation	The process by which individuals control or manage the impressions others form of them in social interaction (Leary & Kowalski, 1990).
Computer-mediated communication	Mediated human–human communication that occurs through computer-based technologies (Carr, 2020).
AI (artificial intelligence)	A field of computer science concerned with designing agents that take inputs from their environment and take actions to maximize their expected outcomes (Russell & Norvig, 2009).
AI-mediated communication	Mediated communication between humans in which AI operates on behalf of communicators to modify, augment, or generate messages to achieve communication goals (Hancock et al., 2020).
Large language models	A class of artificial intelligence models trained on large text datasets to learn patterns of language, which are able to generate human-like language in response to prompts (Brown et al., 2020).
Prompt	A set of input that can direct large language models to generate customized and relevant output (Liu et al., 2023).

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technologies such as email and teleconferencing. Early research focused primarily on the efficiency of computer use in managerial, organizational, and task-oriented contexts (e.g., Hiltz et al., 1978, 1986). Initial theoretical perspectives on CMC, later termed the cues-filtered-out approach (Walther, 1996), emphasized the limitations of text-based channels. These perspectives argued that the absence of nonverbal cues rendered CMC a lean medium, inappropriate for conveying interpersonal and socioemotional information (e.g., Daft & Lengel, 1984; Dubrovsky et al., 1991; Kiesler et al., 1984; Rice & Love, 1987), and low in social presence (Short et al., 1976). These perspectives held that because only limited personal and social information could be transmitted in CMC and users could not get to know each other on a personal level, CMC is inherently *impersonal*. Overall, the cues-filtered-out approach emphasized technological constraints and concluded that CMC was less socially rich than FtF communication and thus less suitable for interpersonal relationships, tasks, and outcomes.

However, empirical research, particularly studies that removed strict time constraints, found that people do exchange social and emotional information online, and can adapt to text-only environments to convey such messages (e.g., Baym, 1995; Rice & Love, 1987; Walther, 1992b). These findings led to the development of alternative theories and frameworks relative to cues-filtered-out models. Among the most influential are the SIP theory (Walther, 1992b) and its extension, the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996). In contrast to the cues-filtered-out perspective, which focuses on technological limitations, SIP emphasized the capacity of CMC to allow different ways to embed social information into messages and the adaptability of individuals to use available cues to fulfill personal and relational goals. It is worth noting that, although this article reviews SIP, we do not seek to extend it directly. Instead, we discuss SIP as a precursor to the hyperpersonal model and as part of the historical context for it.

SIP proposes that *interpersonal* communication is possible in CMC and, given sufficient time, can achieve relational outcomes comparable to those in FtF interaction.

According to SIP, the key difference between CMC and FtF is not in the type or amount of social information that can be exchanged, but in the rate of exchange (Walther, 1992b). SIP assumes that humans inherently seek affiliation and, as adaptive social beings, humans are motivated to engage in relational communication, adapting to the environment to do so. Relational messages, or messages that people use to convey and manage their affections and relationships (Burgoon & Hale, 1984), are encoded and decoded through available cues, which can be both verbal or nonverbal. When nonverbal cues are limited or absent, as in text-based CMC, users adaptively compensate by employing linguistic and paralinguistic cues to convey socioemotional content. Given enough time, the total amount of social information exchanged in CMC can equal that of FtF interaction, producing similar relational outcomes (Walther, 1992b).

A reanalysis of SIP using a longitudinal study comparing the relational outcomes of zero-history FtF and CMC groups revealed that CMC groups, over time, developed more intimate and socially oriented communication than their FtF counterparts (Walther & Burgoon, 1992). Walther and Burgoon (1992) designed a longitudinal study where zero-history triads met three times across five weeks, comparing CMC to face-to-face groups. They tracked how relational dimensions such as immediacy, similarity, and receptivity developed over time. As expected, CMC groups reported lower levels of these relational qualities in the first session, but with extended time for interaction, CMC and FtF groups converged on many relational dimensions, supporting the SIP perspective. Unexpectedly, CMC groups described their interactions as less task-focused and more socially oriented than FtF groups. Over time, CMC groups also showed increased attempts at influence but decreased dominance, became less formal, and expressed greater trust, suggesting the emergence of positive relational climates, exceeding those of FtF groups. These unexpected findings prompted further theoretical development, resulting in the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996), which proposes that CMC can, under certain conditions, produce relational outcomes that surpass those of FtF communication, fostering even more affectionate and intimate relationships.

The hyperpersonal model

The hyperpersonal model offers an account of CMC as enhancing interpersonal intimacy and liking beyond the levels typically achieved in FtF interaction (Walther, 1996). It describes conditions under which CMC can produce better social outcomes than FtF, made possible by the affordances of the medium. Like SIP, the hyperpersonal model assumes that communicators use the cues that are available to encode and decode socioemotional messages. Where it differs from SIP is in proposing that CMC can yield enhanced, rather than merely equivalent, relational outcomes, such as greater intimacy and more intense relationships than those developed in FtF settings. Walther (1996) identified four interrelated classes of effects, including receiver, sender, channel, and feedback, that explain how CMC can become *hyperpersonal* and exceed FtF communication in facilitating idealized social connections.

CMC *channels* differ from FtF interaction in their affordances, or the action possibilities (Gibson, 1977). Four affordances are especially relevant for interpersonal dynamics, including editability (i.e., messages can be revised before being sent), asynchronicity (i.e., communication does not occur in real time), reduced cues (i.e., interaction is limited to verbal and paralinguistic cues), and physical separation (i.e., interlocutors are not physically co-present). For *senders*, these affordances enable selective self-presentation: people can take more time, refine messages, conceal unwanted aspects, and highlight desirable qualities without managing nonverbal cues. Thus, in CMC, senders can have greater control over their images and highlight ideal attributes more readily than in FtF interaction. For *receivers*, limited physical and nonverbal information encourages greater attention to verbal or paralinguistic signals. Drawing on the Social Identity Model of Deindividuation Effects (Lea & Spears, 1991), the hyperpersonal model suggests that receivers overattribute from these limited verbal or paralinguistic cues, often perceiving exaggerated similarity and idealizing the sender. Receivers, guided by idealized impressions, give senders *feedback* in ways that affirm the senders' optimized self-presentations. This positive feedback encourages senders to reinforce and even internalize these desirable portrayals, and

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adjust their own behavior to be more aligned with the idealized version the receiver projects onto them. This cyclical process reflects behavioral confirmation, or a self-fulfilling prophecy.

Empirical evidence of the sender effects

Since its development, the hyperpersonal model has inspired a substantial body of CMC research (Walther et al., 2015), becoming one of the most influential frameworks in the study of mediated communication (Scott & Fullwood, 2020; Walther & Whitty, 2021). This section provides a brief review of empirical evidence related to the sender-side component of the model, namely selective self-presentation, as it is the central concern of this article. For a more comprehensive review of the hyperpersonal model, see prior review papers (e.g., Scott & Fullwood, 2020; Walther & Whitty, 2021).

Direct evidence of the sender effects comes from studies examining how users utilize the affordances of CMC and how channels with varying affordances affect self-presentation. These studies showed that the affordances of CMC shape not only how people construct messages but also the relational outcomes those messages produce. First, CMC affordances influence individuals' compositions of self-presentation messages. Walther (2007) found that in CMC, greater time investment and greater mindfulness in message construction were positively associated with editing behaviors, which in turn increased the immediacy conveyed in messages, consistent with the hyperpersonal model's propositions that asynchronicity and editability facilitate strategic self-presentation. Other studies demonstrated that CMC affords more socially desirable expression than FtF communication: users employed more polite language in media offering greater control, such as email (compared to voicemail) (Duthler, 2006), felt more comfortable self-presenting in CMC over FtF (Madell & Muncer, 2007), disclosed more directly and extensively in CMC than in FtF interaction, which enhanced interpersonal attraction (Antheunis et al., 2007), and discussed more engaging and interesting topics in CMC than in FtF conversation (Berger & Iyengar, 2013). Research on deceptive self-presentation in CMC demonstrates that CMC affordances enable more strategic deception. It is worth distinguishing strategic self-presentation from deception, however. Although they may have some overlap conceptually, strategic self-presentation involves intentionally managing how one is perceived by others and can remain factually accurate, whereas deception specifically involves intentionally creating beliefs about the self that are false or misleading (Levine, 2014). Hancock et al. (2004) found that deception rates varied across media, with the telephone producing more lies than FtF, instant messaging, or email. This result has later been replicated by Markowitz (2022), who also found that lies occurred most in synchronous, distributed, and recordless media such as the phone and video chat. Drawing on these two studies, channel affordances such as synchronicity, physical separation, and recordlessness (i.e., the degree to which a channel cannot preserve a persistent record of the interaction) may facilitate more strategic deception in some modalities (e.g., phone and video chat) than in others (e.g., face-to-face and instant messaging).

Theoretical extensions of the sender effects

While the initial sender effect in the hyperpersonal model focused on how CMC affords selective self-presentation, subsequent research has extended this perspective in two major ways. The first line of work examines the boundaries of selective self-presentation, asking under what conditions people present themselves in ways that diverge from or align with their offline characteristics. The second line considers the outcomes for senders themselves, investigating how engaging in strategic self-presentation shapes the way individuals perceive and evaluate themselves.

For the boundaries of selective self-presentation, although CMC enables people to present themselves in any way they choose, empirical evidence suggests that online self-presentation does not always deviate dramatically from actual characteristics; rather, it often remains largely truthful and consistent with one's offline self (Ellison et al., 2006, 2012; Gibbs et al., 2006). A key framework for explaining the constraints that limit how far online self-presentation can diverge from offline characteristics is warranting theory (e.g., DeAndrea, 2014; Walther & Parks, 2002; Walther et al., 2009), which argues that people avoid exaggeration when claims can be verified by others. DeAndrea (2014) suggested that an audience's prior knowledge of another person and whether one expects to have anticipated future interaction with a target were factors that reduce exaggerated or deceptive self-presentation. The profile-as-promise framework offers another perspective that emphasizes future accountability, proposing that self-presentation in online dating profiles acts as a psychological contract or social promise that others evaluate against the presenter's actual behaviors and characteristics, which constrain presenters to make claims they can fulfill in the future (Ellison et al., 2012). Together, these frameworks extend the hyperpersonal model's sender effect by adding factors related to future verifiability as boundaries, such that people optimize their self-presentation with CMC affordances, but they do so within limits set by what can be verified and what they can fulfill in the future.

The second extension addresses the outcomes of self-presentation, specifically how online self-presentation can influence one's self-perceptions. The concept of identity shift was initiated to refer to self-transformation resulting from self-presentation in mediated environments (Gonzales & Hancock, 2008). Gonzales and Hancock (2008) demonstrated that when individuals' online self-presentations were public, rather than private, their self-perceptions aligned more closely with their assigned self-presentational personality (e.g., extravert vs. introvert). Later research identified moderators such as the presence of confirmatory feedback and feedback source (Carr & Foreman, 2016; Walther et al., 2011), and formalized identity shift theory, which suggested identification with one's self-presentational messages and viewing them as a viable self-image as key antecedents of identity shift (Carr et al., 2021). Recent work shows that internalization depends on the cognitive effort and attention invested in creating the message (Pham et al., 2025). In sum, identity shift research extends the hyperpersonal model by showing that selective self-presentation not only shapes

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receivers' impressions but also feeds back to reshape the sender's own perceptions of themselves.

To conclude what was discussed in this section, the hyperpersonal model holds that CMC, while constraining nonverbal cues, provides novel opportunities for impression formation and relationship development. When leveraged by socially motivated individuals, these affordances can produce interpersonal outcomes that exceed those of FtF interaction. The sender effect, in particular, proposes that CMC users can utilize these affordances to selectively present themselves for more desirable outcomes and that such selective self-presentation can also reshape self-perceptions. Building on the hyperpersonal model, the next sections discuss self-presentation in AIMC, propose two AIMC affordances, and outline the potential outcomes.

Self-presentation in AI-mediated communication

AIMC marks a shift in CMC, as the channel evolves from a passive conduit for delivering messages to an active participant in their production, co-constructing meaning in social interaction with humans (Hancock et al., 2020). Text-based AI models, particularly LLMs, are trained on vast corpora of human communication and can closely mimic human language (Jones & Bergen, 2025). Given this capacity, AI can assist with a wide range of language processing and generation tasks (Hancock et al., 2020; Hohenstein et al., 2023). While traditional CMC emphasizes the control over self-presentation afforded by the channel, AIMC adds a new layer of affordances by shifting some communicative agency to the medium (Hancock et al., 2020; Sundar, 2020), enabling it not only to transmit messages but also to facilitate message production. AIMC thus builds on, rather than changes, the dynamics of CMC, introducing affordances that are unavailable in traditional CMC.

Given the wide range of text-based AI tools, text-based AIMC encompasses diverse forms of mediated communication in which AI plays varying roles in assisting self-presentation (Wenker, 2023). Self-presentation typically requires people to convey desirable impressions, which are shaped by intrapersonal and interpersonal factors (Goffman, 1959; Leary, 1995; Leary & Kowalski, 1990), through observable cues. In AIMC, text-based AI assists individuals in crafting how they appear in front of the audeince, from ideation to performance. For instance, grammar checkers can provide real-time corrections of grammar errors to ensure accuracy of the language so that users' grammar and syntax are correct and appropriate (e.g., Grammarly). Smart-reply applications can suggest short responses predicted to be contextually appropriate so that a quick, efficient, and properly formatted response goes out readily (e.g., Gmail's Smart Reply). LLMs can even generate entire messages based on user prompts, enabling individuals to tailor their self-presentation to the audience or context. The diversity of the AI tools poses challenges for theorizing the role, mechanisms, and impact of AIMC in human communication.

Following the hyperpersonal model, we do not focus on the idiosyncrasies of individual AIMC tools, but instead on the affordances of AIMC that facilitate interpersonal communication and may lead to processes that differ from those in traditional CMC. Rather than tackle the differences between the design of the tools, an affordance lens helps to extract a set of stable and comparable mid-level constructs, which can be measured, compared, and linked to the process and outcomes. This abstraction also helps avoid attributing certain outcomes to the qualities of technologies while failing to make a comparison with other technologies that may have similar effects by enabling cross-channel comparison on affordance dimensions (Walther, 2013).

The hyperpersonal model assumes that relationally motivated individuals adapt to the communication environment, utilizing channel affordances, and leveraging available cues to advance interpersonal goals (Walther, 1996, 2007). The introduction of AI into interpersonal communication creates a novel environment with affordances that can potentially enhance self-presentation. Following the logic of the hyperpersonal model, we argue that AI does not automatically enhance self-presentation; rather, enhancement occurs only when users are motivated to recognize and actualize AI's potential. In other words, motivation sets the conditions that render affordances consequential. The following sections first outline the affordances of AIMC, then explain how motivations shape people's appropriation of these affordances for self-presentation, and finally describe the resulting processes and outcomes.

Channel affordances

The way humans use communication technologies depends not only on the structural features of the technologies but also on what actions they enable or constrain (Gibson, 1977, 1979, 2014). The term *affordance* was initially coined by Gibson (1977, 1979) to describe the possibilities for action available to animals in an object or ecological environment. Gibson's conceptualization considered affordance as inherent to the object that emerges in its relationship with the actors, but does not depend on the actor's perceptions (Norman, 1990). Later, Norman (1990) proposed that although affordances are grounded in the physical or structural characteristics of an object or environment, they are ultimately shaped by users' perceptions and beliefs. Users can perceive the medium as able to afford actions that do not correspond to the actual design of the objects, and the same object may be perceived as offering different affordances depending on a user's goals, experience, and context of use.

In CMC research, affordances can function as a mid-level framework linking technological features to communicative processes and outcomes (Evans et al., 2017; Fox & McEwan, 2017). Prior research on affordances in the field of communication has diverged in how affordances are defined (e.g., Evans et al., 2017; Fox & McEwan, 2017; Ronzhyn et al., 2023), with some work emphasizing affordances as relational constructs and other work emphasizing perceptions of affordances. More recent reviews generally converge on a set of threshold criteria (Evans et al., 2017; Ronzhyn et al., 2023). In this view, affordances are relational (emerging from the user-technology relationship rather than from technical features alone), are action possibilities rather than outcomes (though they can influence outcomes given user goals), they enable and constrain behavior, and they can vary across users in ways that allow measurable differences in perception. In this article, we adopt these criteria to summarize AIMC affordances.

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We define AIMC affordances as the communication actions that are made possible, but not determined, by AI's technological features, and whether the affordances can be realized depending on users' recognition of those possibilities. AIMC, as a special form of CMC, shares the affordances of CMC, namely editability, asynchronicity, and reduced cues. And, importantly, the affordances of AIMC are made possible by those core CMC affordances. It is CMC's asynchronicity and editability that allow senders to consult AI while composing messages.

The affordances of AIMC introduce novel dynamics to self-presentation. In AIMC, self-presentation becomes a co-constructed process, and is shaped not only by traditional CMC processes but also by the interplay between human and AI, which together determine the message and its outcomes. Self-presentation, by definition, is the process of constructing a desirable impression to be presented to others (Leary & Kowalski, 1990). Individuals present themselves not only to express who they are but also to elicit favorable perceptions, approval, and affiliation from others (Leary & Kowalski, 1990; Schlenker, 2003). Leary and Kowalski (1990) proposed several determinants of how people construct impressions, three of these determinants are of particular relevance to relational communication: (a) role constraints and situational norms, which are the expectations tied to the relationship and that interaction context that determine how to self-present is considered as appropriate; (b) the target's values and expectancies, which refers to what the audience is expected to value and what images will be rewarded or penalized; and (c) the actor's current and future social image, that is the audience's existing set of impressions and others' expectations about a person, which restricts how far new self-claims can credibly depart from established impressions. As described below, AIMC's affordances facilitate self-presentation construction and allow for more precise control over self-presentation than is typically achievable in CMC, while those opportunities also come with constraints.

Though previous research has identified the affordances of AI at a general level (e.g., what AI systems enable a person to broadly do; Ramaul et al., 2024; Zhan et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2024), the present article's focus is narrower and more specific, as we conceptualize AIMC affordances as *interpersonally consequential communicative acts and interaction dynamics that become possible when AI participates in message production for human-to-human communication*. Because of this difference in theoretical target, the affordances identified in prior AI affordance work are not directly applicable to our theoretical extension. Thus, we identify and originate affordances through which AIMC distinctively contributes to the encoding process.

Drawing on Goffman's (1959) dramaturgical framework and the Machine-Integrated Relational Adaptation model (MIRA) (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026), we propose two affordances, *co-creation* and *adaptability*. In Goffman's dramaturgical framework (1959), self-presentation involves two stages, including a frontstage, where the performance faces an audience, and a backstage, where preparation occurs, away from the audience's gaze. We borrow this metaphor to describe the relations involved in the self-presentation process (e.g., the relations between self and message backstage and between the message and audience frontstage). Note, while we draw on this perspective to partially motivate our introduction of co-creation and adaptability, we do not use a dramaturgical approach in our theorization. The MIRA model, however, offers an additional account of when, how, and why AI specifically functions as a relational entity in human ecosystems (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026). The MIRA model proposes that AI can operate as both a relational partner (e.g., AI directly working with a human to complete a task) and a relational mediator (e.g., AI indirectly shaping human–human communication).

Building on these frameworks, we argue that co-creation and adaptability *primarily* operate at different stages of self-presentation and shape different components of the self-presentational process, with AI playing different roles in each. Co-creation focuses on the sender-message relationship (i.e., authorship and self-expression) and operates mainly in backstage production. In the MIRA model (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026), co-creation maps most directly onto AI as a relational partner, because it mostly centers on human–AI joint action that occurs prior to and in preparation for human–human interaction. Adaptability focuses on the message–audience relationship (i.e., audience tailoring and contextual fit), and operates mainly at the frontstage. In the MIRA model (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026), adaptability maps more directly onto AI as a relational mediator because it shapes human–human communication by influencing how messages are adapted for specific audiences and contexts.

We acknowledge that these two are not comprehensive and that other AIMC affordances may also be theoretically meaningful. We adopted a parsimonious strategy and prioritized affordances that are most theoretically central to our theoretical extension. We encourage future research to further theorize AIMC affordances. In this article, we focus on co-creation and adaptability as they are most directly relevant to core hyperpersonal models' assumptions about message production and are especially relevant to self-presentation processes, and are more readily mapped into Goffman's (1959) dramaturgical framework and the MIRA model (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026). We dissect these affordances within our theoretical model, below.

Co-creation

Co-creation is an affordance through which humans and AI jointly produce content, such that the final message reflects contributions from both parties through iterative and interactive exchange. With co-creation, AI may provide suggestions or revisions, which the user can edit and ask it to further refine. For example, a person drafting the "About Me" section of a personal website may have a general sense of the image they want to present but struggle to translate it into words. They provide AI with a brief and rough description of their background and ask it to generate an initial draft. They then notice that the AI omitted an important detail and ask it to incorporate that information while maintaining a consistent tone and style. Through several cycles of prompting, revising, and re-prompting, a message emerges that neither the sender nor AI would likely have produced alone. Metaphorically, this is AI acting as a writing partner who will suggest changes and interact with the human before they transmit the final message.

In the process of co-creation, self-presentation is no longer produced solely through the sender's own strategic decisions, but instead emerges through iterative exchanges between sender and AI system, producing something neither would have

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generated alone by the sender or AI. As a result, AIMC changes the sender–message relationship and raises questions about authorship and self-expression, such as who is the actual author of a self-presentational message and the extent to which the message reflects the self the sender intends to express.

Co-creation is made possible by AI's ability to create or revise messages based on users' inputs (e.g., prompts), in an interactive and timely manner (Liu et al., 2023). Unlike earlier language tools that produced one-off suggestions (e.g., grammar checkers, smart replies), advanced systems such as ChatGPT and Gemini can maintain multi-turn conversations, allowing users to regenerate, revise, and re-prompt outputs across multiple cycles, progressively aligning AI responses with self-presentation goals (Ramaul et al., 2024; Zhan et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2024). Table 2 presents the technological features of example AI tools that enable this affordance.

Through co-creation, AI assists the encoding process by adding or enhancing the sender's communicative acts (i.e., augmentation), modifying the sender's draft (e.g., wording, structure, tone) while preserving the underlying claims (i.e., modification), and producing new self-descriptive text from the sender's instructions under the sender's supervision (i.e., generation). In the co-creation process, the role of AI can vary along a continuum from low to high levels of human-AI jointed contribution (Meng et al., 2025). At the high end of co-creation, senders engage in iterative back-and-forth exchanges with AI to refine messages. Here, AI may respond to human-generated content by offering advice, feedback, or revisions to tone and language, while the sender continues to direct, compose, and shape the core message, resulting in a final product that reflects input from both parties while remaining aligned with the sender's intentions. At the low end of co-creation, AI generates the message content based on the user's prompts, reflecting limited joint actions.

Text-based self-presentation often requires translating intentions and feelings into concrete verbal or paralinguistic cues, which is a cognitively demanding task constrained by individuals' working memory, lexical access, and knowledge base. In traditional CMC, message crafting relies only on the sender's cognitive resources and time. Trained on vast human-generated corpora, AIs can produce expressions that exceed a single individual's active memory or linguistic repertoire in real time (Clark, 2025; Matz et al., 2024), and can activate schemas that make otherwise inaccessible information more readily available (Bhat et al., 2023). In the process of co-creating, users are still the ones who hold the agency, strategically deciding how the AI-generated content can be incorporated in the final message. In this sense, co-creation in AIMC extends both ideation and expression, enabling richer self-presentation strategies and helping match their intentions and identity with self-presentation. It influences what topic people choose to present (e.g., Poddar et al., 2023) and how they can present it by offering more precise control during self-presentation (Fu et al., 2024). Through this affordance, individuals can curate and express their identities in ways that align with their desired impressions (Goffman, 1959; Leary & Kowalski, 1990), beyond what they could achieve in traditional CMC without co-creating with AI.

The affordance of co-creation of AIMC differs from collaboration between humans. Humans collaborating in self-presentation is not a new phenomenon (e.g., Schlenker & Britt, 1999, 2001). For example, friends strategically manage what they share about one another to help each other create a desirable impression for the audience (e.g., Schlenker & Britt, 1999, 2001). AI, however, enables a form of assistantship that is otherwise difficult to realize with human partners. Unlike collaboration with humans, co-creating with AI is always-on and already provides fast responses (Noy & Zhang, 2023). In human–human collaboration, interlocutors, who bring diverse perspectives and histories, have to make efforts to lay a common ground (Clark & Brennan, 1991). However, when co-creating with AI, people work in tandem with AI while holding control over the final messages. Contemporary AI systems are always built to be compliant, often agreeing with the users and avoiding conflicts (Sharma et al., 2025). Unlike human helpers, whose intentions and expertise vary across relationships and contexts, AI systems tend to provide broadly consistent assistance across contexts, owing to statistical learning from large and diverse corpora (Brown et al., 2020). Moreover, whereas asking a human for self-presentation assistance can be face-threatening and elicit self-presentation concerns, this concern may be less salient when interacting with an AI system (Diwanji et al., 2025). Thus, co-creation is a unique affordance of AIMC that is different from human–human collaborations.

Table 2 Corresponding features of artificial intelligence-mediated communication (AIMC) affordances.

Artificial intelligence tools (examples)	Features related to AIMC affordances	
	Co-creation	**Adaptability**
Gmail—email writing tool	Compose full email drafts with "Help me write function"; rewrite content to augment (e.g., elaboration, polish)	Built-in functions (e.g., formalize)
Grammarly—general writing tool	Rewrite words, sentences, and paragraphs	Tone detector and tone suggestion based on context (e.g., more professional, confident, polite)
ChatGPT models—large language models-based chatbots	Can be prompted to generate full drafts or augment existing drafts	Can suggest audience-appropriate content and tailor tone or persona based on context
Rizz—dating message assistant	Generates openers and reply drafts from a prompt, bio, or uploaded chat screenshot	Tone selection (e.g., flirty, romantic, funny); contextualizes suggestions to the specific bio or chat uploaded

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Co-creation also comes with constraints. LLMs are trained to identify statistical patterns from large corpora, and their outputs tend to converge toward consensus and show reduced variance. In other words, they often skew toward the *average* (Chayka, 2025; Giorgi et al., 2023). When co-creating with AI, what is compromised is the diversity of people's unique perspectives and independent thinking, which may lead final messages to converge toward homogenization (Agarwal et al., 2025; Kosmyna et al., 2025). Through co-creation, AI may produce content that does not fully align with the sender's true self. When such content is incorporated into self-presentation, it may weaken authenticity, a quality that is central to interpersonal perception (Markowitz et al., 2023).

Adaptability

Adaptability can be defined as the affordance that enables users to draw on AI's capacity to adapt messages in response to the specific demands of a communication context (Ramaul et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2024). For example, someone may need to decline a colleague's invitation to dinner because they are unavailable. The sender shares their initial draft with AI and specifies the relevant relationship and professional context. Without iterative back-and-forth, AI revises the message by adjusting its formality and face-saving language to fit that specific audience and situation. This is essentially AI acting as a newspaper copy-editor before an article goes directly to production. Rather than relying solely on the sender's social judgment and strategic adjustment and accommodation, AIMC can incorporate algorithmic inferences and optimization that help tailor messages to audience cues, situational demands, and desired impressions. This affordance reshapes the message—audience relationship by changing how, and the extent to which, audience tailoring occurs.

Traditional CMC channels do not tailor responses for specific audiences. In CMC, senders themselves adapt and tailor messages to the audience (Walther, 2007). In AIMC, the channel facilitates this adaptation. AIMC's adaptability arises from AI systems' ability to interpret prompts, maintain interaction history, and incorporate situational cues. Trained on large and diverse corpora, LLMs can produce outputs suited to communicative contexts, allowing authors to customize tone, style, and topical emphasis (Matz et al., 2024). Though earlier social robotics and rule-based chatbots (e.g., decision trees, random forests) can exhibit limited tailoring to specific inquiries, what's new with contemporary AI is its ability to keep and retrieve specific information across turns (Ramaul et al., 2024). It can estimate audience- and context-appropriate self-presentation strategies by drawing on statistical patterns in large corpora when the prompt provides enough cues (Ramaul et al., 2024), tuning language and topical emphasis to these predictions. For example, Microsoft Copilot in Outlook can read the recent thread between two interlocutors and suggest context-aware replies.

Adaptability is central to self-presentation as it enables people to project a version of the self fits the context, and is tailored to the audience. As in Leary and Kowalski's (1990) model, self-presentation is shaped by the characteristics of the presenter and the context, by the norms of the situation, and by the nature of the audience. For example, emails to professors or colleagues are expected to be professional and to minimize highly private self-disclosure, whereas messages to a close friend in distress may emphasize empathy and include selective self-disclosure. Similarly, from an interaction adaptation perspective (Burgoon et al., 1995), people enter an exchange with an interaction position, that is, a stance about what they need, expect, and desire. This position is the comparison point for judging a partner's actual behavior. When the partner's behavior meets or exceeds that position, it is generally evaluated more positively. However, people are often uncertain about how to adapt their self-presentation to the context and audience needs. In first encounters with strangers, people often have little information about the partner and cannot reliably predict the audience's expectations and behavior (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). Even with acquaintances, uncertainty can reemerge when situations redefine roles (e.g., from friend to teammate, or colleagues to friends) (Biddle, 1986). Facing such uncertainty, individuals may seek additional information or external assistance (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). Adaptability in AIMC helps reduce this uncertainty by aligning message content and style with role constraints and situational norms.

The adaptability of AIMC also comes with constraints. In interpersonal communication, adaptation between interlocutors is linked to interpersonal outcomes (Burgoon, 1993), and matching with the other can foster mutual understanding and psychological closeness (e.g., Ireland et al., 2011). When adaptation is produced or facilitated by a third party, however, the sender's genuine understanding of the receiver and the sense of closeness may be weakened.

To conclude, this section introduced the notion of affordances and explained how AIMC builds on CMC affordances to introduce novel affordances that both enable and constrain self-presentation compared with traditional CMC. We treat co-creation and adaptability as conceptually distinct and can operate independently. The examples above illustrate this distinction. In the co-creation example, a person building a personal website iterates with AI to develop an "About Me" section that captures their desired image. The central process is recursive human–AI authorship that the user provides ideas, adds missing details, and asks for revisions. However, the message is not being tailored to a specific recipient or relationship, so adaptability is not activated. By contrast, in the adaptability example, the sender already has the basic message content to decline a colleague's invitation to dinner. The sender asks AI to calibrate the language for a specific recipient and professional context. Because the AI produces a context-sensitive revision without extended back-and-forth, this example involves high adaptability but relatively low iteration, which is central to co-creation.

At the same time, we acknowledge that these two affordances often unfold together. Our *backstage* and *frontstage* framing does not suggest a strict temporal boundary or a strict temporal order between these two affordances. Indeed, both affordances can operate across stages. For example, when an online dater drafts an opening message with AI, they are not only negotiating how to express themselves through iterative exchange with AI (i.e., co-creation), but are also drawing on AI's capacity to tailor that expression to what is likely to resonate with a specific profile (i.e., adaptability). Co-creation can occur *frontstage*, as when senders continue to refine messages with AI in the course of the conversation, and also *backstage* during initial message preparation. Adaptability can occur *backstage*, before human–human interaction begins (e.g., when senders use AI to plan or polish a message for a particular recipient), and it can also occur *frontstage*, during ongoing interaction (e.g., when senders adjust messages across turns as conversation unfolds). The key

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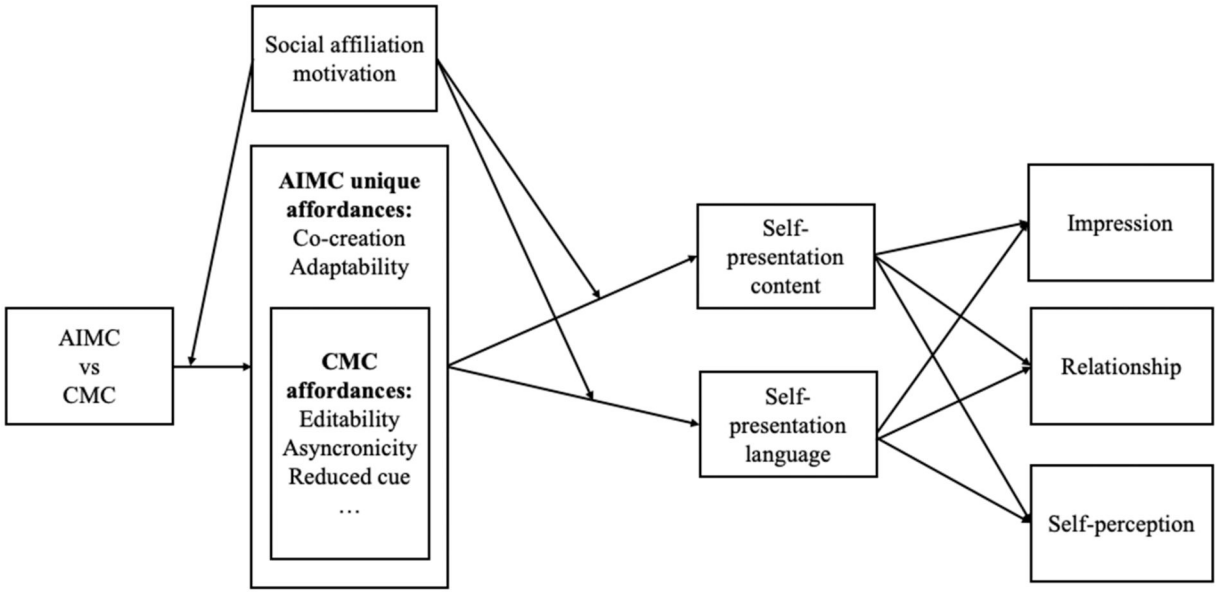


Figure 1 The CARE model of artificial intelligence-mediated self-presentation.

distinction is what each affordance *primarily* reshapes. Co-creation *primarily* reshapes how the self-presentational message is produced, where AI functions more as a partner. Adaptability *primarily* reshapes how that message is tailored for a particular audience and setting, where AI functions more as a relational mediator (Boyd & Markowitz, 2026).

In the next sections, we offer predictions and abstract several propositions. Those propositions together form our theoretical framework, the Computational-Assisted Relational Exchange (CARE) model, to theorize the sender-side mechanisms of AI-mediated relational communication. The model positions AIMC, relative to traditional CMC, as introducing distinct affordances, and social affiliation motivation is theorized to condition individuals' engagement with AIMC affordances (Proposition 1). AIMC's distinct affordances shape self-presentation at both the level of language (Proposition 2) and content (Proposition 3). These differences in self-presentation, in turn, have downstream consequences for impression and relationship formation (Proposition 4) and self-perceptions (Proposition 5). Figure 1 presents the theoretical model. While this article primarily follows a deductive theory–extension approach, we also incorporate current empirical evidence in support of each proposition. This evidence is used as relevant and illustrative support for the theoretical claims, rather than as the primary basis from which the propositions are induced. To guide empirical research, following each proposition, we provide exemplar hypotheses.

Propositions and predictions

Social affiliation motivation

A core assumption of SIP and the hyperpersonal model is that humans are motivated to seek social affiliation (i.e., the desire to be accepted, included, and connected with others) and to present themselves in ways that create favorable impressions to affiliate (Walther, 1992b, 1996, 2007). The need to feel connected to others has also been documented in social psychology research (e.g., Baumeister & Leary, 1995). The affiliation motive drives individuals to use whatever the channel affords to show themselves in the best possible light (Walther et al., 2010). In CMC, the channel affords editability, asynchronicity, and reduced cues. Relationally motivated users thus utilize those affordances to optimize self-presentation, spending more time and effort to encode impression intentions through content (e.g., depth and breadth of self-disclosure and attitude statements) and language style (e.g., tone, emotion, language complexity, and pronoun use) (e.g., Markowitz, 2023; Walther, 2007; Walther et al., 2010). The time and effort invested in editing and composing messages lie at the core of self-presentation in CMC. As Walther (2007) noted, the time spent on message composition reflects an extensive cognitive process, indicating how mindfully senders craft their messages. In relational communication, this mindful composition is associated with higher message quality, as indicated by greater immediacy and a more socially-oriented tone (Walther, 2007).

Following the logic that social affiliation motivation drives individuals' engagement with channel affordances, senders' appropriation of AIMC affordances may also be shaped by how motivated people are to create a favorable impression. When individuals are highly motivated to make a good impression, they may devote greater time and effort to co-creating with AI in order to produce a more effective version of their self-presentation, for example, by producing more fluent expression while maintaining control over content so that it remains aligned with their intentions. They may also work with AI to adapt their self-presentation into a more audience- and context-appropriate form, for example, by calibrating the level of self-disclosure and the tone of the message. Conversely, when individuals are less motivated to manage impressions, for example, when the value or importance of the desired goal is low (Leary &

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Kowalski, 1990), they may invest less time and effort in impression management. In such cases, when AI is available, they may either ignore it or delegate the entire self-presentation process to AI to minimize cognitive effort and time investment.

The underlying premises for the above argument are that AIMC facilitates desirable self-presentation, individuals can recognize this, and those who recognize this potential are capable of leveraging AI to pursue their affiliation goals when motivated. As illustrated in prior research, though not yet systematically theorized, current generations of AI have the potential to facilitate the creation of favorable impressions (e.g., Hohenstein et al., 2023; Yin et al., 2024). The effectiveness of self-presentation depends on both intrapersonal factors, such as the sender's expressiveness and readiness to adapt to situational demands (DePaulo, 1992; Snyder, 1987), as well as the situational and relational constraints that determine what impressions are appropriate (Goffman, 1959).

Making an impression that promotes affiliation requires the sender to effectively encode relational intention into visible cues, such as communicating immediacy through verbal immediacy, conveying trust, and depth through self-disclosure, expressing similarity through first-person plural pronouns (Walther & Burgoon, 1992), strategically expressing agreement and disagreement (Walther et al., 2005, 2010), and accommodating their language to the gender-preferential language of the partner (Thomson et al., 2001). This process can be challenging and not always effective, as individuals may be uncertain about how to present themselves and may not always succeed in translating their intentions into behavior (DePaulo, 1992). When interactants have little knowledge of the partner or how to self-present, they may experience high uncertainty (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). When under salient relational goals, they actively seek to reduce that uncertainty (Berger, 2015; Douglas, 1990), for example, by searching for relevant partner and situational information (Walther et al., 2010). As Berger and Perkins noted, individuals seek to reduce uncertainty to "select optimal messages from their available repertoire to accomplish their goals in an interaction" (Berger & Perkins, 1978, p. 172). From an uncertainty-reduction perspective, turning to AI for context and audience-appropriate content and language serves as an active uncertainty-reduction strategy, through which individuals seek additional information and assistance in situations characterized by high uncertainty (Berger & Calabrese, 1975). This perspective echoes *communication-utility* work, which proposed that people consume media with social purposes in mind, selecting information they expect to use in conversations and relationship building (Atkin, 1972). Given AIMC's co-creation affordance, AI can help expand on ideas users may not have fully articulated on their own, thereby narrowing the gap between how individuals intend to present themselves and what they are actually able to express. In this way, co-creation may enhance the effectiveness of self-presentation. Given AIMC's adaptability affordance, AI can also narrow the gap between what individuals intend to convey and what is appropriate or desirable for a particular audience and context, thereby extending self-presentation beyond individuals' own capacity for audience and contextual calibration.

It is worth noting that strategic use of AIMC affordances for impression management does not guarantee either an authentic (i.e., truthful) or a deceptive self-presentation, and the motivation of being authentic does not necessarily contradict the premise that AIMC affordances facilitate social affiliation. Although some channels are more likely than others to enable deception (Hancock et al., 2004; Markowitz, 2022), the motivation of being authentic is shaped by multiple factors, with channel affordances only one among them. Audience knowledge, anticipated verification, norms, and situational stakes all condition whether a person self-present authentically (e.g., DeAndrea, 2014; DeAndrea et al., 2012; Toma & Hancock, 2010). When senders' authenticity motivation is high, AIMC can still support authentic self-presentation by helping senders highlight context-fitting traits without exaggeration and by refining wording so it is fluent and conveys the intended level of immediacy.

Research has shown that a range of affiliation-related factors, such as audience attractiveness (Walther, 2007) and explicit (vs implicit) affiliation motivations (Walther et al., 2010), influence how people engage with CMC affordances. Traditional CMC does not readily supply external informational or stylistic resources for strategic self-presentation. AIMC does, however. Compared with CMC, AIMC affordances provide a novel communication environment, and motivated individuals can adapt to this environment to construct and present a better possible version of themselves to others. When relational goals are salient, people may be motivated to invest greater effort in leveraging AI's affordances to optimize how they present themselves. AI thus functions as a resource by supplying content exemplars and tailoring content and language to the audience and context. In this sense, individuals' social affiliation motivations set the necessary condition for the AIMC affordances to be actualized.

> Proposition 1: Individuals' social affiliation motivations drive their appropriation of AIMC affordances in self-presentation.

Building on this proposition, future empirical work can derive specific hypotheses about how individuals utilize particular AIMC affordances. For example, potential hypotheses can be that individuals with higher social affiliation motivation may invest more effort co-creating with AI, such as seeking AI's advice, iteratively prompting for more tailored content, and using adaptive features to align messages with audiences and contexts. In contrast, individuals with lower motivation may be more likely to delegate the entire message production process to AI, exhibiting lower levels of co-creation. Potential operationalizations of the key constructs in this proposition are presented in Table 3.

The role of social affiliation motivation in the present framework is primarily upstream, as it shapes how individuals engage with AIMC affordances for self-presentation. At the same time, this antecedent role has downstream implications. To the extent that individuals higher in social affiliation motivation are more likely to engage AIMC and leverage its affordances, the effects outlined in the subsequent propositions may be more likely to emerge, or emerge more strongly, among such individuals. We therefore return to this point later by deriving integrative predictions from the joint logic of Proposition 1 and the downstream propositions.

Message compositions of AI-mediated self-presentation

Having discussed the affordances of AIMC and the motivations in people's utilization of these affordances, how will AIMC (vs.

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Table 3 Operationalization of key constructs.

Construct	Relevant proposition(s)	Operationalization examples
Social affiliation motivation	1	(a) Experimentally manipulated: randomly assign participants to interact with partners varying in social attractiveness, such that the interaction partner is expected to elicit higher or lower affiliative motivation (b) Perception measures: self-report scale assessing the motivation to form social connection (Mehrabian, 1970)
Co-creation affordance	1	(a) Experimentally manipulated: manipulate the extent to which participants can shape artificial intelligence (AI) output through their own input, editing the resulting output, and incorporate AI output into self-presentation messages. For example, participants could be randomly assigned to conditions that differ in the degree of control they have over AI-generated self-presentational content, ranging from acceptance-only to prompt-based revision to full editing access (b) Behavioral indicators: include the extent to which the sender prompts AI for message-production advice, whether AI-generated content is accepted or edited, and the relative proportion of AI-generated and human-generated text retained in the final self-presentational message (c) Perception measures: include self-report items assessing perceived co-contribution and the extent to which both the participant and the AI shaped the final message
Adaptability affordance	1	(a) Experimentally manipulated: manipulate whether AI can tailor content to audience or context, such as a fixed generic-output condition versus a condition in which AI can be prompted to generate the message based on relational target or context goals (b) Behavioral indicators: prompt requests for tone or style adjustment (c) Perception measures: self-report items assessing the extent to which the sender felt the AI enabled contextual adjustment or audience targeting in the self-presentation process
Relational tone	2	Could be operationalized through human coding of verbal cues of relational communication (Walther & Burgoon, 1992), or linguistic indicators such as affiliative language and emotional tone.
Context-appropriate and audience-targeted content	3	Could be measured through coder ratings of context appropriateness, and audience fit, or by comparing message variations across different relational or situational targets.
Impression and relational outcomes	4	Could be measured through partner-report or observer-report scales after exposure to the self-presentation message, such as perceived warmth and competence (Fiske et al., 2007), attraction (McCroskey & McCain, 1974), liking (Veksler & Eden, 2017), and intimacy (Miller & Lefcourt, 1982)
Identity shift	5	(a) Experimentally manipulated: assign participants to create self-presentations that emphasize specific traits, such as extraversion or introversion, either with AI assistance or without it, and then compare post-interaction self-evaluations on those focal traits (b) Observational: could be assessed through pre-post changes in self-views of the traits or claims highlighted in one's self-presentation

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CMC) influence the processes and outcomes of self-presentation? Self-presentation, as an impression construction process, involves a set of choices and decisions about what to include (e.g., topics, details, breadth or depth of self-disclosure) and how to say it (e.g., formality, politeness, emotionality) to project desired attributes and relational intentions. In CMC, communicators' adaptation to a channel's affordances affects the content, style, and relational tone of their messages (e.g., Antheunis et al., 2007; Duthler, 2006; Walther, 2007).

Relational tone of messages is central in SIP and the hyperpersonal model because relational communication closely relates to communicative effectiveness and satisfaction (Walther, 1992a). Early relational–communication research did not separate message content (i.e., what topics are discussed) from language (i.e., how words are used). Instead, it treated relational tone as perceptions, typically measured with interactants' or third-party observers' judgments (Burgoon & Hale, 1984; Walther, 1992a; Walther & Burgoon, 1992). Subsequent CMC work on self-presentation moved toward incorporating objective analyses, distinguishing between content (Antheunis et al., 2007; Tong et al., 2020) and language style (Bazarova et al., 2013; Markowitz, 2023; Walther, 2007). This delineation matters because producing content cues and producing language style cues likely engage distinct cognitive processes. Content choices tend to be more deliberative, whereas style choices, although they can be intentional, are often less consciously controlled and may more accurately reveal impression management attempts (e.g., Bazarova et al., 2013; Chung & Pennebaker, 2008).

Self-presentation language style

One notable influence of AIMC is how AI's involvement influences the language of self-presentation. Having AI modify and edit sender-written content, indeed, is the most used quest related to writing according to the recent OpenAI's ChatGPT usage report (Chatterji et al., 2025). Human language carries important social meanings that serve impression and relational purposes (Walther et al., 2015). The *word-as-attention* framework considers words as clues to people's internal states, attentional focus, and social–psychological experiences (Boyd & Markowitz, 2024; Pennebaker, 2011). In self-presentation, attempts at impression management are often revealed in language style (Bazarova et al., 2013; Markowitz, 2023). In CMC in particular, people strategically adapt linguistic and paralinguistic cues in self-presentation for different audiences (Walther, 2007). For example, Walther (2007) found that in CMC, people's pronoun use and language complexity differ when addressing different audiences.

Then, how does AIMC systematically shape people's self-presentation language? Broadly consistent with dual-process models of information processing, which distinguish between more deliberate and more automatic forms of processing (e.g., Chaiken, 1980; Evans, 2008; Kahneman, 2011; Petty & Cacioppo, 1986), we propose that AIMC affects self-presentation language style through two routes. The distinction between deliberate and automatic forms of processing is useful here not because we seek to apply the dual-process model to AIMC. Instead, we use it as a heuristic for distinguishing between intentional and goal-oriented use of AIMC affordances and more automatic stylistic changes over the course of human–AI interaction. We propose that one route through which AIMC influences self-presentation language style is a strategic or deliberate route, in which senders intentionally draw on AIMC affordances to optimize their self-presentation language to achieve their relational goals. The other is an automatic route, through which senders gradually converge toward AI's linguistic style over the course of repeated interaction, integrating its patterns without necessarily intending to do so (Giles, 1979, 2008; Giles et al. 2025; Gonzales et al., 2010; Pickering & Garrod, 2013). These two routes are not mutually exclusive and may co-occur within a single interaction. Although the automatic route can be more contingent because AI's linguistic tendencies may vary depending on model training and alignment procedures, the strategic route should be more robust. Even when AI's linguistic patterns vary, senders can still engage with AIMC functionally to pursue self-presentational goals. We elaborate on each route below.

For the strategic route, AIMC senders intentionally use AI affordances to construct messages and adapt their language to the relational demands of the interaction. Prior research shows CMC senders strategically adapt their language, for example, adjusting personal pronoun use and language complexity, to their relational context (Walther, 2007). CMC affordances allow senders to invest more time and more cognitive resources in the encoding process. AIMC can make this process easier by helping find wording, polish phrasing, and align tone with context. With the *co-creation* affordance of AIMC, AI involvement can vary along a spectrum depending on how senders use and prompt the system. At lower levels of co-creation, senders incorporate AI-generated phrasing directly into their messages. At higher levels of co-creation, senders engage in an iterative back-and-forth with the AI, refining drafts as the system suggests wording and directs attention to what to emphasize or omit. Through *adaptability*, senders can prompt AI to align the message with the appropriate style in contexts.

The second route is more automatic and subtle. AI may also shape style through senders' accommodation to the AI's language over the course of interaction. Senders may adjust their language to converge toward the AI's linguistic style, especially when they develop a sense of social relationship with the AI system and become motivated to accommodate to its language style (Giles, 1979, 2008; Giles et al. 2025). Repeated iterations with AI may also lead users to pick up its language style (Gonzales et al., 2010; Markowitz, 2024; Pickering & Garrod, 2013; Toma, 2014). AI and human language often diverge in theoretically meaningful language dimensions (e.g., Fu et al., 2024; Giorgi et al., 2023; Hohenstein et al., 2023; Markowitz et al., 2024; Sharma et al., 2023). Although LLMs are pretrained on human-generated text, many widely used LLMs are designed to follow clear behavior goals, such as being broadly helpful while avoiding harm. For example, OpenAI trains models with reinforcement learning from human feedback and evaluates outputs in terms of being helpful and harmless, explicitly defining harmlessness as not causing physical, psychological, or social harm (OpenAI, 2024). Relatedly, Anthropic's Constitutional AI approach uses a set of principles to guide both supervised training and reinforcement learning to produce a more helpful and harmless assistant (Bai et al., 2022). Together, these alignment approaches may introduce a systematic bias toward pro-social

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and carefully framed language, which can make LLM outputs warmer and more polished than average human messages, even though they are trained on human-generated text. Studies comparing AI-generated and human-written text find that AI tends to generate language that is more emotional, positive, and polite (Fu et al., 2024; Giorgi et al., 2023; Hohenstein et al., 2023; Markowitz et al., 2024; Sharma et al., 2023). These linguistic stylistic tendencies of LLMs often align with socially desirable norms such as warmth, empathy, and politeness (Giorgi et al., 2023; Meng et al., 2025; Sharma et al., 2023). More importantly, these tendencies coincide with the immediacy cues (i.e., language approachability and regard that create psychological closeness) that are critical for affiliation in mediated interpersonal communication (O'Sullivan et al., 2004).

Through either or both routes, AIMC can shape self-presentation by directing the sender's attention toward particular ways of saying things and by allowing AI's language patterns to seep into the sender's own message (Anderson et al., 2025). In either case, the final message may show convergence toward AI's style, though the degree of convergence varies (Hohenstein et al., 2023). Research has shown that working with AI in message production influences the final language style, resulting in the final content being more relational in tone (Hohenstein et al., 2023; Mieczkowski et al., 2021; Sharma et al., 2023). While the results presented here do not include every possible use case for AI and language use, studies were selected based on their topical relevance to the current theoretical interests.

> Proposition 2: Compared with CMC, AIMC tends to produce self-presentation with a more relational tone.

Because AI systems evolve quickly, specific hypotheses derived from this proposition may change. Accordingly, we offer exemplar hypotheses grounded in current language tendencies of AI as illustrations. For example, compared with CMC, AIMC produces self-presentation messages with more positive-emotion wording and a more positive overall tone.

Self-presentation content

AIMC might affect people's self-presentation content, which includes the topics, details, and self-disclosures that a person includes. CMC users encode the aspects of themselves into content cues. Drawing on Brunswik's (1956) lens model, Tong et al. analyzed online daters' profile texts (Tong et al., 2020). They showed that daters encode self-rated traits in the topics they mention in the profile. For example, people who rated themselves high in extraversion discussed spending time with others more often, those who rated themselves as charismatic mentioned more specific qualities about themselves, and those who rated themselves as less confident and ambitious talked more about life aspirations.

AIMC can help senders encode aspects of the self into self-presentation content targeted to specific audiences. With the *co-creation* affordance of AIMC, AI can shape content by proposing candidate topics, claims, examples, and phrasings that can be inserted directly into the message or that shape message construction indirectly by expanding people's knowledge base and assisting memory extraction, or exerting an anchoring effect, whereby AI suggestions become a default reference point (Doshi & Hauser, 2024; Fogliato et al., 2022). Through *adaptability*, prompted guidance, or more advanced systems that can reference conversation history (e.g., Microsoft Copilot in Outlook), helps tailor message content to context norms and audience expectations. AI-generated text and AI-provided advice tend to be contextually sensitive (Ramaul et al., 2024). When facing different audiences, individuals highlight different skills, accomplishments, and personality traits. In this sense, AI-mediated self-presentation expands the content pool for context-appropriate self-presentation, giving senders richer material to select from strategically. Empirically, research found that when the AI was fine-tuned to suggest particular topics (e.g., hobbies and interests, work and education), people were more likely to write about the suggested topics than about others (Poddar et al., 2023). By contrast, without AI's contribution (i.e., CMC), senders rely solely on their own recall and perspective, which typically yields more personalized and distinctive content, with greater variability in contextual appropriateness.

> Proposition 3: Compared with CMC, AIMC produces self-presentation content that is more context-appropriate and audience-targeted.

The exemplar of hypotheses derived from this proposition can be that compared to CMC, AIMC self-presentations will more closely align with audience expectations that follow from the relationship between sender and audience, audience characteristics such as gender, age, and power status, and the situational norms of the setting.

Impression and relational outcomes

Given the divergence between AIMC and CMC in the composition of self-presentation messages, it is reasonable to expect these differences to translate into differences in perceivers' impressions and relationship outcomes. Before proceeding, it is important to distinguish the impression and relational outcomes examined in this article from the receiver effects posited by the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996). In this article, the impression and relational outcomes of AI-mediated self-presentation refer to consequences of affordance-enabled cue optimization, that is, how AIMC's co-creation and adaptability allow senders to curate messages in a way that impressions and relationships systematically differ from traditional CMC. By contrast, receiver effects in the hyperpersonal model emphasize idealization processes that arise as receivers interpret cues (Walther, 1996; Walther et al., 2015).

As discussed above, AIMC is more likely to yield self-presentations that fit context norms and meet audience expectations. Several theoretical perspectives suggested that meeting context norms and audience expectations shape impressions and relational perceptions. Appropriateness of self-presentation is a key determinant of impressions and relationship formation in first encounters (Chaikin & Derlega, 1974; Qin et al., 2025). From a communication competence perspective, the ability to be appropriate may indicate whether one is a competent communicator (Spitzberg, 1983). Expectancy violations theory holds that messages that meet, or positively violate, expectations predict more favorable outcomes (Burgoon, 2015). In stranger encounters, expectations of the partner's behavior largely mirror situational social norms (Burgoon & Hale, 1988). Moreover, in CMC, studies find that positive norm violations yield more

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favorable impressions than positive normative self-presentation (D'Angelo & Van Der Heide, 2016). If AIMC messages skew more positive, they may make positive norm violations more common or more intense, which could strengthen the impression boost associated with positive norm violations. Taken together, these perspectives suggest that AIMC's tendency to produce more norm-consistent or positively norm-violating messages, alongside audience-tailoring, should lead to more favorable impressions and thereby greater relational outcomes, relative to CMC.

At the same time, as discussed above, AIMC's influence on language style may steer impressions to have more emotion, positive, polite, and supportive. These features correspond to higher message immediacy (O'Sullivan et al., 2004), and are also generally associated with rapport, trust, liking, and affiliation in mediated interaction (e.g., Qin et al., 2025; Spencer-Oatey, 2005). Given the more positive language typical of AIMC, relative to CMC, it should produce more favorable impressions and better relational outcomes.

> Proposition 4: Compared with CMC, AIMC self-presentation leads to a more favorable impression and better relational outcomes via the effects on self-presentation language and content.

For this proposition, testable hypotheses can compare post-interaction impressions and relational perceptions. For example, in zero-history dyadic interactions, individuals who use AI during the conversation will be evaluated more favorably by their partners, elicit greater liking, and prompt partners to report stronger intentions to continue the interaction. In a more static context, such as online dating, AI-assisted self-descriptions lead profiles to be rated more favorably and to elicit greater willingness to initiate a chat.

It is worth noting that although Proposition 4 primarily concerns how AIMC self-presentation may influence impression and relational outcomes through changes in language and content, impression formation is likely more nuanced than a direct effect of message features. Warranting theory provides an important lens for understanding this complexity (e.g., DeAndrea, 2014; Walther & Parks, 2002). It proposes that people do not rely on all cues about an online target equally when forming impressions. They assess the warranting value of those cues, or the extent to which a cue is perceived as difficult for the target to manipulate and therefore informative about the target's actual offline qualities. In the context of AIMC, if receivers notice or suspect AI involvement in message production, the warranting value of verbal cues may be attenuated (Zhu et al., 2025). Receivers may be less likely to treat socially desirable language as direct evidence of the sender's characteristics if they believe the language was substantially shaped by AI. In this case, receivers' knowledge or suspicion of AI involvement may attenuate the impression benefits of AIMC. We return to this issue in the *Future directions* section, where we elaborate more on receiver-side processes in AIMC and directions for future research.

Self-perceptions

If AI helps people present a more favorable version of themselves, does it also affect how they see themselves? Before people started to interact online, classic social-psychology work had shown that self-presentation can change people's perceptions of themselves (Bem, 1967; Fazio et al., 1981; Schienker et al., 1994; Tice, 1992). In CMC, although the hyperpersonal model does not directly theorize the downstream effects of self-presentation on senders' self-perceptions, identity shift research offers an important related sender-side extension by demonstrating that online self-presentation can reshape self-perception, especially when it is public and receives confirmatory feedback (e.g., Carr, 2021; Gonzales & Hancock, 2008; Walther & Lew, 2022; Yee & Bailenson, 2007). A similar mechanism likely operates in AIMC, but its strength may depend on the cognitive effort invested and psychological relatedness to the message (Carr, 2021; Pham et al., 2025). Although identity shift theory does not emerge directly from the hyperpersonal model, we see it as helping elaborate sender-side effects that are less fully specified in the hyperpersonal model. Because self-presentation is central to this article, incorporating this discussion helps clarify how AI-mediated self-presentation may influence not only interpersonal outcomes but also the sender's own psychology.

As discussed above, AIMC may produce self-presentation that is more desirable and positive than what senders would have produced on their own. Overly positive self-presentation may not always benefit the sender psychologically. This tendency resembles toxic positivity in online self-presentation, where an emphasis on positivity can suppress negative or less favorable aspects of one's perceived reality (e.g., Lew & Flanagin 2025). Positivity facilitated by AI may improve the surface-level social desirability of a self-presentational message, but the senders may not commit to it if they experience that positivity as exaggerated or suppress their perceived reality (Lew & Flanagin 2025). This logic is consistent with early evidence that positive self-statements can backfire when they conflict with one's existing self-image (Wood et al., 2009).

At the same time, while AI assistance improves drafting efficiency, it can also create cognitive trade-offs. Delegating whole or partial composition tasks to AI reduces the mental effort users devote to the process, thereby lowering cognitive engagement (Gerlich, 2025; Lee et al., 2025; Stadler et al., 2024). Neuroscience evidence shows that consulting LLMs induces the lowest cognitive load and engagement compared with using a search engine or relying solely on one's own cognition (Kosmyna et al., 2025). The reduced cognitive efforts can affect how users relate to their self-presentations. Psychological ownership develops when people experience personal investment in a target and perceive that they have contributed to its creation or development (Pierce et al., 2001). When users contribute little, they may feel less ownership and lower identification with the message (Endacott & Leonardi, 2022; Joshi & Vogel, 2025), weakening any identity-shift effect (Carr, 2021; Pham et al., 2025). Identity shift theory and research on behavior-induced attitude change suggest that, for behaviors to influence people's attitudes, individuals need to identify with their actions and see themselves as responsible for them (Carr et al., 2021; Cooper & Fazio, 1984). AI may interrupt this process by functioning as an external source of responsibility. If people attribute their desirable self-presentation to AI rather than to themselves, they may experience a weaker identity shift.

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Proposition 5: Compared with CMC, AIMC will yield a weaker identity shift following self-presentation.

An exemplar hypothesis is that, when instructed to present oneself in a particular way that highlights specific traits, such as extraversion, individuals who co-create a self-presentational message with AI, compared with those who compose it entirely in their own words, will show lower shifts in self-perception toward those traits.

Derived predictions: social affiliation motivation as moderators

Based on the above discussion and propositions, we further derive the predictions as logical extensions of the foregoing propositions and specifically outline that the effects of Propositions 2 to 5 may vary as a function of social affiliation motivation. As discussed above, social affiliation motivation drives people's use of AIMC affordances (Proposition 1). Individuals with stronger affiliation motives are more likely to invest more effort and more strategically leverage co-creation and adaptability to craft more desirable messages. Consequently, highly affiliation-motivated senders should see larger gains in relational tone (Proposition 2) and contextual appropriateness (Proposition 3) than less motivated senders. These message-level gains should translate into more favorable impressions and relational outcomes (Proposition 4), as, similar to in CMC, in AIMC, receivers form impressions from the verbal messages. Thus, affiliation motivation operates as a moderator of AIMC effects on both message features and outcomes.

Prediction 1: The effect proposed in Propositions 2–4 will be stronger among individuals with stronger social affiliation motivations.

Following the logic above, motivated senders are likely to invest more cognitive effort in crafting messages and engage more deeply in the process. Adjacent evidence suggests that deeper engagement may strengthen identification with an AI-assisted self-presentation. Deeper engagement in co-creating with AI can increase users' cognitive efforts and sense of ownership over the resulting message (Joshi & Vogel, 2025). Greater engagement with AIMC's co-creation affordance may also help users align the final message more closely with their intended image, through iterative evaluation and revision (Wan et al., 2024). In this way, deeper engagement with AI may lead motivated senders to identify more strongly with their AI-mediated self-presentation than less motivated senders. According to identity shift theory (Carr et al., 2021), such identification is an antecedent of the identity shift process.

Prediction 2: The effect of Proposition 5 will be attenuated among individuals with stronger social affiliation motivations.

Discussion

A central question in communication and technology research is whether and how technology (e.g., AI) influences the way we communicate with one another and what outcomes such communication may produce (Hancock et al., 2020). Amid the efforts to update, extend, and rethink communication theory and to push the boundaries of communication research to include AI (e.g., Hancock et al., 2020; Meng et al., 2025; Shin, 2021; Sundar, 2020; Xu & Shi, 2024), this article provides an account of how AI-mediated self-presentation unfolds and the outcomes it may generate. This focus is significant because self-presentation is the basis on which others form impressions, the starting point for relationship initiation, and a process with far-reaching consequences for both relational development and individuals' relationships with themselves.

This article builds on the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996). As one of the most influential CMC theories, the hyperpersonal model explains why and how impressions formed and relationships developed in CMC can at times exceed those in FtF interaction. Revisiting and extending classical CMC theories for AIMC is crucial. The hyperpersonal model explains human–human communication under computer-mediated conditions and specifies how interaction unfolds and with what outcomes. When AI is involved in the interpersonal process, the hyperpersonal model warrants reexamination to assess which assumptions and predictions still hold.

Focusing on sender effects (i.e., selective self-presentation), we examine why and how AIMC enables more optimized self-presentation and, in turn, more favorable impressions and better relational outcomes, while noting the boundary conditions under which these effects hold, resulting in the CARE model. This article shared the core assumptions with the hyperpersonal model, namely, humans are socially motivated, adaptive to channel affordances, and strategically engaging with the channel affordances leads to selective self-presentation (Walther, 2007). While the core logic of the hyperpersonal model still holds, AI introduces new affordances that enable distinctive forms of self-presentation. Extending the hyperpersonal model, this article considered AIMC as CMC with an additional layer of AI, which brings affordances that are not available in CMC. In the hyperpersonal model, senders construct messages themselves prior to transmission. AIMC alters this process. Co-creation expands the self-presentation options available to the sender, such as detailed facts, examples, and phrasings. Adaptability helps align language style and content with contexts. Together, these affordances increase control over self-presentation and more readily produce desirable impressions.

Research agenda

Perhaps the most important contribution of this article is that, by advancing a set of testable propositions, it invites systematic empirical investigations of how AIMC unfolds and what outcomes it produces, using CMC as the comparison benchmark. Although prior work has examined how AI assistance shapes self-presentational message composition (e.g., Fu et al., 2023; Poddar et al., 2023), few studies directly compare AIMC with CMC (though, see Hohenstein et al., 2023), constraining what we can conclude about AI's effects on interpersonal dynamics. We propose a research paradigm that extends established CMC effects to AIMC settings, asking what changes when AI is involved and how outcomes differ from traditional, human-only

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CMC, resulting in the CARE model (Hohenstein & Jung, 2020; Hohenstein et al., 2023; Liu et al., 2024; Zhu et al., 2025). While we do not examine differences among AI tools, it also invites comparisons of AI systems that differ in the levels of the affordances and an examination of their effects on interpersonal dynamics, both against each other and against traditional CMC.

We propose a research agenda to test the propositions advanced in this article and to move AIMC research forward. First, it is worth conducting a within-person comparison that examines how the same individual produces qualitatively different self-presentation messages in content and language when using AIMC versus traditional CMC, and how these effects differ for audience-elicited different social affiliation motivations. A within-person design isolates changes attribute to the channel by holding individuals' stable characteristics constant. It helps reduce between-person confounds by controlling for traits such as personality, language proficiency, and other individual-difference factors linked to self-presentational motives (Nezlek & Leary, 2002).

Second, research should investigate dyadic interaction in which one or both partners have access to AI, compared with no access, and identify how motivational factors such as relational closeness and anticipated future interaction condition how AIMC senders appropriate AIMC affordances during message production, as well as partners' evaluated impressions and relational outcomes. Also, importantly, compare the language produced across these conditions, examining differences in content and style (e.g., tone and immediacy markers). This design allows us to examine how AI-mediated self-presentation unfolds over turns in social interaction and to trace how specific AIMC affordances (i.e., co-creating with AI and using AI for adaptation) are appropriated throughout the process.

Third, examine how using AI for self-presentation versus traditional CMC influences senders' subsequent self-perceptions. This line of research explores how AI-mediated self-presentation shapes the way people perceive themselves. Following identity-shift work in CMC (e.g., Gonzales & Hancock, 2008; Walther et al., 2011), producing descriptions of oneself may lead senders to internalize the traits they articulate. AI-mediated self-presentation may introduce content or language that aligns with or diverges from people's preexisting self-perceptions. Research should test how alignment or misalignment produces changes in self-perception, and how cognitive load or arousal during message construction, as well as attribution of responsibility for desirable self-presentation, shape these shifts. Researchers can also examine moderators, including individual differences (e.g., self-concept clarity, public self-consciousness), authorship attribution, audience type, and feedback appearance.

Limitations and future directions

This article has limitations and leaves a few important questions for future research to address. One limitation is that although this article highlights a set of affordances particularly relevant for social interaction, other affordances may also play crucial roles in AIMC (Ramaul et al., 2024; Zhan et al., 2024; Zhang et al., 2024). Future research could work on extending and further explicating the affordances of AIMC. In this article, we primarily address short-term or one-shot interactions, but future research should also examine long-term consequences as AIMC becomes increasingly embedded in everyday life (Yang & Brown, 2016). Moreover, because LLMs continue to evolve, studies should also investigate the evolving patterns of AI-influenced language and content rather than only focus on the features of any single model (Yakura et al., 2025).

Moreover, we did not systematically identify boundary conditions that may moderate AIMC-CMC differences. Several psychological factors are likely to shape how people use AI in self-presentation. For example, the relational context may condition the strength of the effect proposed in this paper. While we expect the core dynamics we describe to apply across a range of interaction settings, including both weak-tie and strong-tie, we acknowledge that these processes may vary in their strength across such settings. This is because relational contexts differ in relational history and norms and expectations surrounding media use (e.g., Taylor & Ledbetter, 2017). Therefore, relational context can be an important potential boundary condition and an avenue for future research. Also, individuals' mental models of AI can shape what they believe the AI tool is able to do, which may influence how they use AI and how much self-presentation advantage they can gain from using AI. People's personal perceptions and relationships with AI systems and the extent to which they attribute minds to these systems can also influence how they interact with AI (e.g., Lee et al., 2020), how much they trust AI due to the specific characteristics of the AI systems (e.g., Shin, 2021), and how they integrate AI-augmented text into their self-presentation. In addition, metacognitive strategies, or the degree to which people actively monitor and regulate their cognition to achieve goals, may determine how clearly they can specify the image they want to project in a given context, and thus how effectively they can use AI to achieve impression management goals (Sun et al., 2025). Other factors, such as individuals' AI literacy, prompting skill, prior AI experience, and time constraints, are also likely to shape when AIMC outperforms CMC and when it does not. Systematically mapping these boundary conditions can be an important task for future research.

As noted throughout this article, the affordances of AIMC do not merely enhance self-presentation but also introduce important constraints. In particular, AIMC may involve both intrapersonal and interpersonal costs. Through its co-creation affordance, AI may generate content that does not fully reflect the sender's true self. If senders incorporate such content into their self-presentation, authenticity may be undermined, which is central to interpersonal perception (Markowitz et al., 2023). At the same time, the separation between presented content and the sender's self may disrupt identity shift processes, given that identification with one's self-presentational claims is a key precondition for such shifts (Carr et al., 2021). Through its adaptability affordance, AI may facilitate interpersonal adaptation and attunement without requiring the sender's full psychological engagement, creating the possibility of surface-level coordination without deeper relational understanding or mutual attunement. These tensions and countervailing dynamics warrant further theorization and empirical investigation.

Beyond the focus of this article, the involvement of AI in language production raises broader questions for the psychology of language. Language has long been considered to reflect individuals' internal states and personal traits (Pennebaker & King, 1999). In AIMC, however, language emerges as a synthesis of human and AI joint contributions. Current AI models provide responses based

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on the statistical pattern learnt from massive datasets to make predictions of the next probable word or token (Vaswani et al., 2017), and their output can be human-like yet not anchored in the sender's lived experience and psychology, which are the very features human language reveals (Pennebaker & King, 1999). This shift challenges core assumptions in the psychology of language about what linguistic cues reflect and how. For example, pronoun use has been linked to depression in human-generated text (Rude et al., 2004), yet such links may attenuate or become unstable in AI-assisted messages. Future work should specify when AIMC-generated text can be interpreted as indicators of the sender's psychology and when it cannot. Another language-related topic worth noting is the relational consequences of AI language's tendency toward the *average*. In this article, we treat this as a constraint because it may compromise individuals' unique and independent perspectives and cognitions. However, averageness does not necessarily produce negative impressions or relational consequences. Research on facial attractiveness, for example, finds that average faces are often judged as attractive (Langlois & Roggman, 1990).

Another relevant issue is truthfulness self-presentation. The tension between desirable and authentic self-presentation is not unique to AIMC. CMC research on deceptive self-presentation has long examined how people manage the self-enhancement-authenticity trade-off (e.g., Ellison et al., 2006; Markowitz & Hancock, 2018; Toma & Hancock, 2010; Toma et al., 2008). Although AI-mediated self-presentation is not equivalent to deception, the literature offers useful insight into how this tension can shape individuals' differential use of AI. AIMC may heighten this tension by lowering the cost of producing polished language and by making it easier to include content that the sender did not author. As in CMC, however, the truthfulness of self-presentation is also likely bounded by relational factors (e.g., stakes, anticipated future contact, and setting norms), which should be examined in future research.

Moreover, future research should continue extending the hyperpersonal model to AIMC by examining receiver, channel, and feedback effects. For example, for receiver effects, whether the receiver knows or suspects AI's involvement and how AI is involved are critical factors in how the AIMC messages are evaluated (Proposition 4). Knowing or suspecting AI involvement may reduce the warranting value of self-presentation, as receivers see the cues as less diagnostic of the sender's actual attributes (e.g., DeAndrea, 2014; Walther et al., 2009; Zhu et al., 2025). This may further lead to less favorable impressions and relational outcomes (Zhu et al., 2025). Empirical evidence showed that in real-time CMC, when the senders used smart replies, they were perceived by the receivers as more cooperative, affiliative, and less dominant. However, when the receivers suspected the sender was relying on smart replies, they rated that partner as less cooperative, affiliative, and more dominant (Hohenstein et al., 2023). Moreover, AI-generated summaries of email threads and conversation threads are becoming increasingly common. For instance, Slack AI and Copilot in Outlook can summarize ongoing exchanges, and such summaries may become consequential cues to impression formation. Future research should systematically examine impression formation, as well as feedback and channel effects, in AIMC relative to CMC.

Conclusion

In this article, we advance theorizing on self-presentation in AIMC by extending the hyperpersonal model (Walther, 1996). We conceptualize AIMC as CMC in which AI functions as an added layer that contributes to message production. We move beyond applying the hyperpersonal model to a new context and instead revisit and extend its core assumptions in light of AI's role in shaping communicative processes. Drawing on the hyperpersonal model and related theoretical developments, we identified two AIMC affordances (i.e., co-creation and adaptability) and advanced the CARE model. We discussed how social affiliation motivation may shape the appropriation of those affordances, and how these processes may influence message composition, impression formation, relational outcomes, and even senders' psychology. Taken together, this article presents a theoretical account of self-presentation in AIMC, proposes a research agenda to test the propositions advanced here to move AIMC research forward, and provides guidance for future empirical work through examples of operationalization of key constructs and derived hypotheses.

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Conflicts of interest

No potential conflict of interest was reported by the authors.

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